

▼ GANAPATHY P. RAJKUMAR, *59*

| DMK | *Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu*



The defeat of the voluble state BJP chief K. Annamalai was an event that registered nationally, but who was the victor? Someone who cut his teeth in the AIADMK, and stayed there from 1989 to 2020. Loyalty ran thin after a long sense of feeling sidelined, and Rajkumar switched to the DMK. Four years later, he has helped the Dravidian major win the Coimbatore seat for the first time since 1998. Elected councillor in 2001, and mayor from 2014 to 2016, he gets by alright with small-scale business and farming.

▶ NILESH LANKE, *44*

| NCP (SP) | *Ahmednagar, Maharashtra*

Call it hubris or naive folly, but Dr Sujay Vikhe Patil, incumbent MP and BJP candidate, had thought it a good campaign idea to mock his challenger's command over English and Hindi. Voters spoke a different language: the neurosurgeon (and son of revenue minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil) was trounced. The earthy Lanke knew all soil types too: once with the Shiv Sena, he joined the NCP and wrested the Parner assembly seat from mentor Vijayrao Auti in 2019. He backed Ajit Pawar's splinter NCP but reversed just in the nick of time.





▲ EATALA RAJENDER, *60*

| BJP | *Malkajgiri, Telangana*

If we're talking political conversions, this one probably traces the longest and most dramatic arc. Eatala's roots lie in left-wing extremism, now he's a rising star in the BJP. In between, he helped K. Chandrasekhar Rao during his agitation phase, evolved into a campaigner for separate statehood, became an MLA seven times, even rose to be FM. But KCR's "authoritarian ways" led to unease, and he decamped to the BJP in 2021. Now he represents one of Asia's largest constituencies. With a thriving poultry and egg business, he is not one to count his chickens before they hatch but Eatala is a front-runner to be the next state BJP chief.

IMRAN MASOOD, *54*

| CONGRESS | *Saharanpur, UP*

The former MLA, who rejoined the Congress just before the Lok Sabha polls, had changed three parties in the last three years.



LALJI VERMA, *69*

| SP | *Ambedkar Nagar, UP*

After the rough and tumble of student politics in the Awadh town of Tanda and early Janata Dal dabbling, the six-time Kurmi MLA was a BSP stalwart till he joined the SP just before the 2022 polls.



RUCHI VIRA, *62*

| SP | *Moradabad, UP*

A brief excursion to the BSP in 2019 apart, Ruchi has been a Vaishya face for the SP who prefaced her present win—as a last-minute replacement—with a debut 2014 win in a Bijnore assembly bypoll.



MADHAVANENI RAGHUNANDAN RAO, *59*

| BJP | *Medak, Telangana*

In 2013, the former statehood campaigner in the then TRS got disillusioned with its founder, K. Chandrashekar Rao, and left the party to join the Congress. He moved to the BJP in 2014 and became an MLA.

